10 MORE LINES, AND WHAT TO SAY WHEN YOU'RE LOST

What to Say to Your Engineers in Your First Month

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1 When you check in, ask what's in the way

Ask about what's holding them up this week.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Anything I can help with?"
> Instead say: "What's one thing I could take off your plate this week?"
> Don't say: "Just checking in on this."
> Instead say: "Is anything waiting on me or another team?"

Write it down, go fix it, and let them know when it's done.

2 When you need a date, ask what it costs

Before you ask for a date, find out what it would take.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Is end of month still realistic?"
> Instead say: "What's the riskiest part between now and end of month?"
> Don't say: "Can we squeeze this in?"
> Instead say: "What drops if we add this?"

If something has to drop, you're the one who tells everyone else.

3 When you want to stay out of the way, read first

Read what they wrote first, then come with a question about it.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Ping me if you need anything."
> Instead say: "I read the design doc. Can I ask about the retry part?"
> Don't say: "I'll stay out of the technical stuff."
> Instead say: "Walk me through it once, and I'll read the rest myself."

Do the reading before the meeting so you're not catching up while they talk.

4 When you're sizing work, ask what it touches

Find out what else this change could break, and what they still need to figure out.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Is this a big lift?"
> Instead say: "What else breaks if we change this?"
> Don't say: "Ballpark, how long?"
> Instead say: "What would you need to find out before you could size it?"

If another team owns any of it, give them a heads up.

5 When you need them, say what and when

Just say what you need and when you need it.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Sorry to bug you again."
> Instead say: "One question on the export bug. Got a minute?"
> Don't say: "Whenever you get a chance."
> Instead say: "Can you look at this before 3? It's blocking the release notes."

If it's not urgent, put your questions in one message so you're not pinging them all day.

6 When you don't follow what they said, say it back

Repeat it back in your own words so they can correct you.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Okay, makes sense." (when it doesn't)
> Instead say: "Let me say it back. We can't ship until the other team updates their API, right?"

If you got it wrong, they'll just correct you, and now you actually know.

Check before your next 1:1 with an engineer

Run this before you walk in:

- [ ] Are you going to ask what's slowing them down?
- [ ] If you need a date, do you know what it would take?
- [ ] Did you read the doc or PR first?
- [ ] Do you know what this change could break?
- [ ] Did you say what you need and when?